

RECORD OF THE REGULAR MEETING OF THE BROOKLINE SCHOOL COMMITTEE HELD ON **THURSDAY, MARCH 14, 2013** AT 6:15 PM IN THE JAMES F. WALSH SCHOOL COMMITTEE ROOM, TOWN HALL. STATUTORY NOTICE OF THIS MEETING WAS FILED WITH THE TOWN CLERK.

School Committee Members Present: Mr. Morse (Chairman), Ms. Ditkoff (Vice Chairman), Mr. Chang, Ms. Charlupski, Ms. Cox, Ms. Kershaw, Ms. Scotto, Ms. Stone, and Dr. Warren. Also present: Dr. Lupini, Mr. Rowe, Dr. Fischer-Mueller, Dr. Allen, Mr. Reed, and Ms. Coyne.

Others Present: Chris Avery

1. ADMINISTRATIVE BUSINESS

a. Calendar

Mr. Morse called the meeting to order at 6:15 PM. He noted upcoming events on the calendar.

b. Consent Agenda

Mr. Morse expressed his appreciation to the Brookline High School Class of 1972 for establishing a memorial scholarship.

ACTION 13-14

On a motion of Ms. Stone and seconded by Ms. Kershaw, the School Committee voted (Ms. Charlupski abstained because she was not at the February 28, 2013 meeting) to approve the items included in the Consent Agenda.

- 1) Past Record: February 14, 2013
- 2) Past Record: February 28, 2013
- 3) Out-of-State Trip Application: Baker School 8th Grade to New York City; June 12, 2013-June 13, 2013 (Attachment A)
- 4) Out-of-State Trip: Brookline High School Baseball Team to Cooperstown, New York; May 10, 2013-May 12, 2013 (Attachment B)
- 5) Establishment of the Brookline High School Class of 1972 Memorial Scholarship (Attachment C)

2. SUBCOMMITTEE REPORTS

a. Finance

Ms. Kershaw reported that the Finance Subcommittee met on March 11, 2013 to discuss the addendum to the Superintendent's FY 2014 Budget Message. Discussion focused on the difficulty associated with this budget and whether there are additional revenue options to fund important programs.

b. Capital Improvements

Ms. Charlupski reported that the Capital Improvements Subcommittee met on March 8, 2013 to discuss space issues, concept school possibilities, and the possibility of

modulars for the Lawrence School. The Subcommittee discussed the costs and benefits of modulars and then voted unanimously to recommend that the School Committee vote to approve up to four modulars for the Lawrence school. Ms. Scotto will be the point person on modulars. Ms. Kershaw asked if there will be engagement with the community on issues such as transportation, placement, and aesthetics. Ms. Charlupski responded that Dr. Lupini is in the process of scheduling an evening community meeting. Ms. Stone has contacted the neighborhood association. Ms. Kershaw stressed the need to engage and not just inform the community on the modular issue and also on the placement of the kindergarten classes. Ms. Charlupski stated that there will be input from the community before the architects move forward.

ACTION 13-15

On a motion of Ms. Charlupski and seconded by Ms. Stone, the School Committee voted unanimously to approve up to four modulars for the Lawrence School.

Ms. Scotto reported that the Building Commission met on March 12, 2013. The Pierce Auditorium project is moving ahead; work continues on the Runkle School; work on the Heath School is almost completed; the town has not heard back on the Massachusetts CHPS application.

c. Curriculum

Ms. Scotto reported that the Curriculum Subcommittee will be meeting on March 21, 2013 to discuss the Devotion School Improvement Plan.

d. Government Relations

Ms. Stone had nothing to report at this time.

e. Negotiations

Dr. Warren reported that the Negotiations Subcommittee will be scheduling a meeting with representatives of the Food Service Workers.

f. Policy Review

1) Proposed PSB Policy on Criminal History Checks of Employees, Volunteers and Others (2nd Reading/Vote)

Ms. Kershaw stated that she has been advised by counsel that due to her employment with the Department of Children and Families, she should recuse herself from the discussion and vote on this proposed policy on criminal history checks. Ms. Kershaw recused herself and left the room during the discussion and vote on this policy.

Ms. Stone referred to the proposed PSB Policy on Criminal History Checks of Employees, Volunteers and Others (Attachment D). There are no substantive changes to the draft presented on February 28, 2013.

ACTION 13-16

On a motion of Ms. Stone and seconded by Dr. Warren, the School Committee VOTED UNANIMOUSLY to approve the PSB Policy on Criminal History Checks of Employees, Volunteers and Others, as shown in Attachment D.

Discussion/voting on the policy ended. Ms. Kershaw returned to the room.

Ms. Stone reported that the Policy Review Subcommittee met on March 13, 2013 to discuss the school residency requirement and the form and frequency of proof of residency. The Subcommittee also discussed the school policy on use or rental of school space or entire buildings, specifically how principals should allocate space, how to collect fees, and how to make the policy more transparent. Ms. Stone will be presenting draft policies at the Subcommittee's next meeting on April 24, 2013.

g. Additional Liaisons

Ms. Charlupski reported that she attended a Brookline Early Education Program (BEEP) Connections meeting on March 5, 2013. The Parent Child Home Program fundraiser was a big success.

Ms. Ditkoff reported that the Brookline Education Foundation Trivia Bee and raffle will take place on March 22, 2013.

Ms. Ditkoff reported that the School Strategic Plan Committee met this afternoon. The Committee held one of three parent and community forums. The Committee has made great progress and hopes to conclude its work by May or June. In response to a question from Ms. Stone, Ms. Ditkoff stated that the Committee could either present the goals to the School Committee in the spring or wait until the fall when the action plans and benchmarks will also be ready. The Committee is sponsoring an Education Learning Series (presentations on core lessons learned from research/national best practices and implications for Brookline). Presentations will take place during regularly scheduled School Committee meetings. The first of these presentations will be this evening.

Mr. Morse reported that the Committee on Brookline School Population and Capital Exploration (B-SPACE) met on March 11, 2013. The Committee discussed new school concept options and how to best keep the community informed regarding the B-SPACE process and public hearings (April 8, 2013 and May 13, 2013).

3. PUBLIC COMMENT

Chad Ellis, a Runkle parent and Precinct 12 Town Meeting Member, stated that he was speaking on behalf of many members of the community concerned with the proposal to eliminate the Enrichment and Challenge Support (ECS) Program. Mr. Ellis noted that ECS is a broad program that serves a range of students, directly through in class lessons and indirectly by furthering teacher differentiation. Advanced learners have real needs and must be engaged. The program is cost effective.

Meredith Huntley, Heath School Music Teacher, spoke against proposed reductions in the music program. She spoke about how the cuts would impact all elementary students and noted the impact of music on students' ability to learn. Some parents can't afford private lessons so there is an equity issue.

Alya Guseva, a Driscoll parent, spoke against the proposed elimination of the ECS Program. The program helps to keep advanced learners engaged and motivated. Not doing so can lead to behavior issues. They need to move beyond a cookie cutter approach to education.

4. SUPERINTENDENT'S REPORT

Dr. Lupini provided the following report:

Staff Recognition

Dawn Carney, Coordinator of World Languages (K-8), has been elected to the Board of Directors of the Massachusetts Foreign Language Association (MaFLA) for a four (4) year term. Thanks to Dawn for her willingness to represent Brookline and her field on this important Board.

Bob Thomas, Educational Technology Specialist at Driscoll School, has been selected as a recipient of the Golden Foundation for Excellence in Education award, which will be presented at Watertown Middle School on Thursday, April 11, 2013. Award winners are recognized for outstanding achievements and contributions in their classrooms, schools, and communities. Congratulations to Bob on this well deserved honor.

Steps to Success

Oneda Horne will serve as Interim Director of Steps to Success (STS) for the remainder of the 2013-2014 school year following the resignation of Carrie Weatherhead. Because of the sudden nature of this resignation, we want to reassure STS students, families and supporters that Steps remains strong and vibrant. Furthermore, we are thrilled that Ms. Horne, who has worked in STS as College Success Initiative (CSI) Advisor for the past three (3) years, was willing to assume this larger role.

We will be working with the Board of Directors to create a timeline and process for hiring the next Coordinator of this important program. Our goal is to have someone in place by July 1, 2013.

Thanks to our STS staff members (J.T. Lenocho, Amber Gadde, Kendell Jones, Melissa O'Brien and Marissa Drossos) who have continued to do amazing work with our students and their families during this transition.

5. SCHOOL COMMITTEE ACTION

a. 2013-2014 School Early Dismissal Dates

Dr. Lupini stated that he hopes to present a proposal on March 21, 2013. It is critical that parents/guardians get this information as soon as possible.

6. PRESENTATIONS AND DISCUSSIONS ON CURRENT ISSUES

a) Brookline Education Learning Series

Ms. Ditzhoff introduced Professor Chris Avery, Faculty Advisor to the Strategic Data Project at Harvard, to provide a presentation on the Strategic Data Project (Attachment E). Professor Avery provided an overview of the work of the Strategic Data Project; explained how they do diagnostic analysis; discussed the concepts of “Summer Melt” (typically about 20% of students who report specific college plans at the time of high school graduation do not enroll the next fall) and “Undermatch” (students attending less-selective institutions than they were qualified to attend). It might be useful to match Brookline’s data with the National Student Clearinghouse to track students through to college graduation.

School Committee members expressed their appreciation to Professor Avery for his interesting and informative presentation. Committee members and Professor Avery discussed some of the factors that might contribute to “Summer Melt,” including finances and lack of information on available options. Ms. Stone commented on the success of Brookline’s Steps to Success program in increasing college admittance/graduation rates. In response to a question from Ms. Stone, Professor Avery stated that public colleges provide a reasonable and affordable option for some students. Ms. Scotto stated that colleges need to put supports into place.

b) FY 2014 Superintendent’s Budget Message Update

Dr. Lupini provided an addendum to his FY 2014 Budget Message (Attachment F). He stated that the FY2014 budget development process has already proven to be one of the more difficult in recent memory. Reductions and efficiencies have been proposed to programs and services that many characterize as essential to the heart of a prominent public school system like Brookline. Unfortunately, the situation has improved only marginally since he presented his initial version of the spending plan on February 28, 2013. At this time, he is able to propose modifications in several areas (health insurance, special education services, high school sections, lead teachers) that will result in an additional \$321,000 for allocation in FY 2014. Dr. Lupini stated that he recommends allocating the additional funds to Coordinators (original proposal included replacing the Winthrop House and Opportunity for Change Coordinator roles with one new position; revised plan includes funding for both of the original coordinator positions; cost of this modification is \$96,000) and a General Education Contingency (establish a general education contingency account of \$225,000 for enrollment increases, additional elementary sections and specialists, and the need for additional sections at Brookline High School). The Town Administrator has recommended that the Town’s share of health insurance savings (\$133,000) be re-allocated to the Reserve Fund to protect against potential impacts from possible reductions to Federal aid.

School Committee members are justifiably concerned about many of the reductions that are proposed in the FY2014 spending plan. As a result, many proposals to generate additional revenue were discussed at the recent Finance Subcommittee meeting. One proposal was to allow for parents or community groups to contribute funds

on a one-time basis to support the Enrichment and Challenge Support (ECS) restoration proposal (with certain conditions). Another proposal was to implement a charge for full-day kindergarten (with a scholarship program). While he does not recommend either of these options, the administration stands ready to provide the School Committee with additional information, including an implementation plan, for either or both options on or before the March 21st meeting.

In response to a question from Ms. Stone, Dr. Lupini stated that they have typically budgeted \$200,000 for a General Education Contingency. In response to a question from Dr. Warren, Dr. Lupini stated that the original ECS budget reduction did not include benefits. Both Ms. Kershaw and Mr. Morse stressed the need to maintain a reserve for enrollment, noting that past expenditures have been higher than what was initially budgeted. In response to a question from Ms. Scotto, Dr. Lupini stated that five of the seven ECS positions qualify for group health insurance.

c) FY 2014 Budget Presentation

Dr. Lupini introduced Deputy Superintendent for Administration and Finance Peter Rowe to present the FY 2014 Budget (Attachment G). Mr. Rowe referred to the guiding principles used to build the budget; explained revenue/expenditure changes built into the FY 2014 budget; described increases for program improvements (general and special education), enrollment, freeze restoration/grant contingency, other contingency; and explained the budget reductions.

School Committee members expressed their appreciation to Dr. Lupini, Mr. Rowe and the other senior administrators for their work in creating this budget. The School Committee members thanked the members of the public who submitted such thoughtful, informative and respectful letters on the impact of proposed budget reductions. Mr. Rowe stated that the chart showing the changes in state aid (FY 1993-FY 2014) is in constant dollars. Ms. Stone noted the additional impact of inflation on the budget over time. Mr. Rowe stated that the administration will coordinate with the Steps to Success Program on the initiative to increase student access to technology. Mr. Chang stated that there has been tremendous growth in some budget areas, e.g., enrollment and collective bargaining, and there is budget uncertainty, e.g., enrollments and out-of-district placements. He does not want to restore one program at the cost of another program and believes the School Committee should consider all revenue sources as a stop-gap measure before finding a long-term solution to the revenue problem. Ms. Stone stated that she agrees with Mr. Chang that their options for the coming year are limited. Seeking additional revenue through an override would take time. Relying on private contributions and charging for full-day kindergarten present issues. In response to a question from Ms. Stone, Dr. Lupini stated that Mr. Rowe believes it would be very difficult to go beyond the one classroom consolidations already proposed. He would not want to go down a path that would increase class size. Mr. Reed stated that he hopes that reductions do not negatively impact the more disadvantaged students at the high school. Teachers and staff should have the opportunity to provide input before cuts are made.

Ms. Scotto spoke against additional classrooms consolidations and ECS cuts. Consolidations increase class size, which impacts teachers' ability to individualize and differentiate instruction. ECS provides support to classroom teachers and helps them to differentiate instruction. All students benefit. Dr. Warren stated that he has concerns with all of the options, but in the absence of additional revenue, budget reductions will be necessary. Ms. Cox commented that the ECS model has changed over the years and it now reaches many more children. She would be reluctant to charge for full-day kindergarten because not everyone would enroll and it would fracture school communities. She would like to explore the option of private fundraising. Ms. Ditzoff noted the amount of collaboration that went into the development of the budget. There is a lot of positive vision in this budget and it reflects a commitment to many critical programs, e.g., METCO, English Language Learners, special education services, technology. She is concerned about the chipping away of excellence that has occurred as enrollment has increased while revenues have stayed the same. The community outpouring has been not just about ECS, but also about rigor and the need for every child to be challenged. Ms. Charlupski recalled the budget cuts of 1994, which were followed by an override. Charging for full-day kindergarten is regressive, is not educationally sound, and presents an equity issue. ECS is a valuable program. Ms. Charlupski suggested looking at one-time reserves. Ms. Kershaw stated that every piece of this budget has been scrutinized and they are out of options. No one likes these choices. They need to create a longer-term plan to meet the needs of all learners. Mr. Morse stated that his own inclination is to take a hard look at revenue rather than a hard look at cuts.

Dr. Lupini stated that he and senior staff have had preliminary discussions on a potential option, which would allow community contributions to partially pay for staff salaries associated with ECS under certain conditions; implement a \$1,000 per student fee for full-day kindergarten; allocate some additional reserve funds; reduce the number of sections to be eliminated at Brookline High School; restore a base level of funding for ECS; and allocate additional funds to technology. Ms. Ditzoff noted that the private funds would have to be raised in a short time. Mr. Chang stated that neither of the two options (private fundraising and kindergarten fee) is ideal, but one is controllable and has certainty. Mr. Morse asked if members were opposed to exploring these ideas. Dr. Warren asked for clarification on what would happen if the funds were not raised. Ms. Kershaw, Ms. Charlupski and Ms. Scotto talked about the value of early childhood education and stated that they are against charging for full-day kindergarten. The public hearing on the FY 2014 budget is scheduled for March 21, 2013 at 8:30 PM.

7. PROPOSED EXECUTIVE SESSION

By unanimous roll call vote at 9:55 PM, the School Committee entered into Executive Session for the purpose of discussing litigation because an open meeting may have a detrimental effect on their litigating position. Mr. Morse noted that the School Committee will reconvene in open session at the end of the executive session for the purpose of adjourning. By unanimous roll call vote at 10:26 PM, the School Committee reconvened in public session.

8. NEW BUSINESS

There was no new business to discuss.

9. ADJOURNMENT

Mr. Morse adjourned the meeting at 10:26 PM.

Respectfully Submitted,

Robin E. Coyne, Executive Assistant
Brookline School Committee